SPOILERS · OPEN AFTER PLAYING

The complete route

NORTH ⁄ THE QUIET GARDEN ⁄ CLOCK ⁄ 1105

1. The letter

The five lines start with **N, O, R, T, H**. Read in order, those initials point to the NORTH shelf. The note's reference to a "beginning" directs attention to the first letters.

2. The shelf

Position	Book
1	The Dusk Letters
2	The Glass Orchard
3	The Quiet Garden
4	The Hidden River
5	The Weather Atlas

The two adjacent pairs are Glass Orchard / Quiet Garden and Hidden River / Weather Atlas. Quiet Garden must be before Weather Atlas, so the first pair comes before the second. Dusk Letters must be before Glass Orchard. Together, these conditions fix the row shown above. The middle book is **The Quiet Garden**.

SPOILERS · EXPLANATIONS

The object and combination

3. The catalogue

The Quiet Garden's inscription is **XOLXP**. Mirroring the alphabet gives X ↔ C, O ↔ L, L ↔ O, X ↔ C and P ↔ K: **CLOCK**. The locked drawer is in the clock's wooden base.

4. The work log

Work completed	Time
Start	09:45
Archive plates: +22 minutes	10:07
Shelf labels: +17 minutes	10:24
Wrapped papers: +26 minutes	10:50
Wooden base: +15 minutes	11:05

The total is 80 minutes. The finishing time is **11:05**. Removing the colon gives **1105**. Both minute digits are required; 115 would not be a four-digit combination.

FOUND
The first folio is in the drawer beneath the reading-room clock. The paper trail identifies the correct shelf, book and object before providing the combination.

EPILOGUE

The first unwritten hour

The brass wheels settle beneath your fingertips. For a moment, nothing moves. Then the latch gives, softly enough to be mistaken for another tick.

Inside the clock's base is a narrow paper parcel. Ada lifts it into the lamplight. The ribbon leaves a clean stripe across the brown wrapping, as if the years have collected everywhere except the place someone took care to protect.

There is one title page, written in a small, deliberate hand: A Map of Unwritten Hours. Below it stands the name Elias Rowan. A pencilled sentence waits at the bottom: "For anyone who has ever found the right door inside the wrong book."

A second note is in Elsie's hand. "People called the manuscript lost because they were looking for one finished object. Elias left it in six gatherings. This is the first. I kept his trail because I wanted the next keeper to discover the shop as he did: by paying attention."

Ada turns the page. The first paragraph describes a city whose library lends hours instead of books. An hour of courage. An hour of forgiveness. An hour to say what should have been said before the door closed.

Outside, the evening's first visitor pauses beneath the shop sign. Ada carefully lays the folio on the archive table. There are five more gatherings to find. For tonight, though, the oldest story in Bellwether Books has finally reached a reader.

END OF CASE 01